



CHOUHAN (LEFT) WITH VIJAYVARGIYA;
THE LAND THAT WAS ALLEGEDLY 'SOLD'
BY VIJAYVARGIYA (RIGHT)

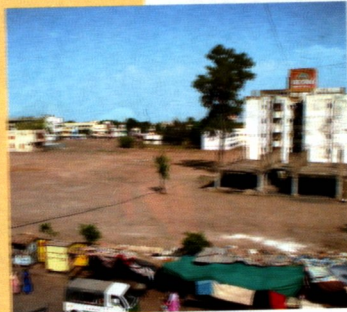
entrench his hold over the Malwa region and Indore. His party rivals now sniff a chance of getting back at him.

The timing of the sudden and focused spotlight on the Vijayvargiya affair is curious as Chouhan himself is named in another complaint to the Lokayukta. In all, seven cases are currently pending investigation by the ombudsman against cabinet members, including two against Chouhan. In 2008, the number of cases against the cabinet members was 16; in 2009,

Case FILES

A number of cases are pending against Chouhan and his cabinet colleagues

In October 2007, the Lokayukta registered an FIR against Chouhan and his wife Sadhna Singh following a local anti-corruption court order in response to a petition by a Congress leader. The chargesheet or final report for closure in the court is awaited. A Preliminary Enquiry (PE) was instituted against Chouhan again in case number 19/08 in 2008. The Lokayukta usually institutes a PE on complaints unless a court orders it to register an FIR. At its peak in 2008, the state BJP Government's ministers, including Commerce and Industry Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya, were facing 16 PEs. A PE is also pending against former chief minister Babulal Gaur. The number of PEs against ministers is down to seven in 2010 because some complaints have been "disposed" while some others against whom PEs are lodged are no longer ministers.



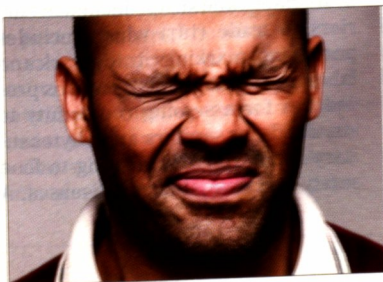
it fell to 14. But never has the blow-up been so explosive. Even as Chouhan's public image remains blemish-free, the opposition Congress has risen in unison to put the state Government in a tight spot over the Vijayvargiya episode. Party's bigwigs like AICC General Secretary Digvijay Singh, state chief Suresh Pachouri and election campaign chief Ajeya Singh—who usually don't see eye-to-eye with each other—have unanimously demanded Vijayvargiya's head. The party also threatens to overwhelm the special session of the Assembly with the issue scheduled in May.

The sudden storm that has hit

Chouhan—who has made a drive against corruption the calling card of his second term—has all the makings of a tipping point with uncanny parallels with former chief minister Digvijay Singh's reign. Though

Singh's first term was mired in land scams, it didn't keep him from a repeat victory in 1998. It was not until land scams in Indore surfaced that Singh's government hit a downslide in its second term.

Chouhan's stint has followed more or less the same trajectory as Singh's with little impact of the dumper controversy in his first term. However, if he doesn't contain the negative fallout from the adverse publicity his government is getting now, it could prove to be a make-or-break point for him and the land scam could forever alter the public perception of Chouhan's Government.



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